USSR will sign a peace treaty and the sovereignty of the GDR will be observed. Any violation of that sovereignty will be regarded by the USSR as an act of open aggression against a peace-loving country, with all the consequences ensuing therefrom." When Kennedy asked whether a Soviet–East German treaty would affect US rights of access to West Berlin, Khrushchev responded in the affirmative. As the unpleasant debate continued, he declared that the Soviet Union could not wait and would sign a treaty by the end of the year giving East Germany control over access rights to West Berlin.

The tensions grew, the two leaders soon began to talk war instead of peace. When Kennedy responded to Khrushchev's mention of Soviet World War II losses that the United States wanted to avoid another war precisely to avoid such losses, Khrushchev responded angrily. "[I]f the US should start a war over Berlin, there is nothing the USSR could do about it," exploded the Soviet leader. He turned again to the miscalculation theme: "ours is a joint account and each of us must see that there is no miscalculation." He could not get off the topic of war: "If the US wants to start a war over Germany, let it be so; perhaps the USSR should sign a peace treaty right away and get it over with.… If there is any madman who wants war, he should be put in a straitjacket." Kennedy was taken aback: Khrushchev was threatening the president with war.[15]

Kennedy's attempt to return to the question of Berlin in private conversation with Khrushchev later that day brought no results. Khrushchev was adamant: "force will be met with force." Kennedy ended the discussion with the words, "it will be a cold winter."[16]

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KENNEDY RETURNED TO THE UNITED STATES WITH WHAT HE believed was his second major defeat on the international stage in less than two months. He felt beaten up. "Pretty rough?" asked James Reston of the *New York Times*, immediately after his last meeting with Khrushchev. "Roughest thing in my life," came Kennedy's candid response. He assumed that he had been treated that way because of the Bay of Pigs debacle. Khrushchev "thought